

► CUTTING EQUIPMENT

Scissors are absolutely essential in quiltmaking and you should have at least three pairs: one dedicated to cutting fabric; one for paper or card and wadding; and

a small, sharp pair for snipping threads. A rotary cutter speeds up fabric cutting.



Pinking shears

Useful for cutting fabric that tends to fray.



Small sharp scissors

Use for snipping thread ends, clipping seams, and trimming seam allowances. A specialized version of small scissors called appliqué scissors can be helpful in appliqué work. The blades are curved to protect fabric that is not being trimmed from being damaged by sharp points, but appliqué scissors should not be seen as a replacement for ordinary small scissors.



Cutting shears

These come with blades of varying lengths. Buy good-quality shears, ideally ones that can be resharpened.

Seam ripper

Used for removing stitching that has gone awry. It incorporates a small cutting blade.



Rotary cutter

Used with a quilter's ruler and self-healing mat, this makes light work of cutting fabric, and especially of cutting through many layers at the same time. Handle with caution.



Craft knife

This is invaluable for cutting stencils from template plastic. Never use it on fabric.

Self-healing mat
Marked with a grid in 2.5cm (1in) increments, the surface "heals" itself after cutting with a rotary cutter, leaving it smooth and without any notches or grooves that might catch the cutter next time you cut. Do not use with a craft knife.

